

The Other Guys

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Introduction

In 2020, while the world was in the midst of an entire shutdown, the Los Angeles Lakers were on top of the basketball world. The franchise won its seventeenth championship in front of floor-to-ceiling screens with Zoom calls on them. The Lakers won the most unique championship in NBA history with one of the most unique teams you will ever see.

The 2020 Lakers were the oldest team in the NBA. At the top, the duo of LeBron James and Anthony Davis were the stars who commanded this group. While they were magnificent in the playoff run, those two were teammates for five seasons, and 2020 was the only season they were able to win a ring. One could argue that health and age were the main reasons, but the 2020 Lakers had the perfect mix of players to finish the job.

This paper is not about LeBron or AD. This is about the other guys on the 2020 Lakers. The impact players who made huge contributions towards the Lakers' pursuit of a ring. Some of those impacts were easily spotted and some required extensive digging. The Lakers got huge boosts from unlikely sources in the 2020 playoffs.

Supercomputer

Entering the 2020 playoffs with Los Angeles, Rajon Rondo's NBA career had hit an awkward period. The Lakers were Rondo's sixth team in six seasons. He clashed with Mavericks coach Rick Carlisle before getting benched for the rest of the 2015 playoffs, he was caught in the middle of DeMarcus Cousins's and George Karl's beef while on the Kings, and he had a falling out in Chicago[3]. The thing is that he had highlights during this difficult three-year span. He led the league in assists in 2016 and he played two brilliant playoff games while leading the Bulls to two wins in Boston against the 1-seed Celtics. In 2018, he had a 25-assist explosion as a member of the Pelicans.

Rondo's two seasons in Los Angeles contributed to a very unfortunate trend: Horrible injury luck. From 2016-20, Rondo suffered FIVE separate hand injuries.

- He broke his thumb in Game 2 of the first round of the 2017 Playoffs [6].
- He broke a bone in his right hand and tore a ligament in the same hand in 2018-19, causing him to only play 46 games all season [1].
- He fractured his finger in 2019-20 [2].

Rondo entered the NBA bubble at 34 years old with a broken thumb he suffered in practice [1]. He didn't play a single second of the eight bubble regular season games and he missed the entire Portland series. The Lakers were already missing Avery Bradley, so they signed Dion Waiters and J.R. Smith. Not exactly household names at this point in their careers.

Rondo did not have a strong 2019-20 regular season:

48 games (3 starts), 20.5 min, 7.1 pts, 5.0 ast, 3.0 reb, 49.4 *TS%*
 Minutes, points, assists were all lowest since rookie year

However, Rondo being active was a huge boon for the Lakers. Waiters and Smith played a combined 84 minutes in the five games against Portland. The only other true lead ball handler on the roster, Quinn Cook, played 19 minutes in the series. The Lakers desperately needed a secondary playmaker and offensive initiator coming off the bench.

Rondo returned for the Western Conference Semifinals against Houston and had an immediate impact:

Gm	Score	MIN	FG	3PT	FT	REB (OFF)	AST	TOV	STL	PTS	+/-
G1	97-112	25	3-9	2-5	0-0	3 (0)	4	4	2	8	-10
G2	117-109	29	4-9	1-5	1-2	3 (0)	9	1	5	10	+28
G3	112-102	30	8-11	3-5	2-2	2 (0)	9	3	1	21	+7
G4	110-100	29	5-8	1-2	0-0	10 (3)	8	3	1	11	-4
G5	119-96	21	1-4	1-1	0-0	5 (1)	5	2	1	3	+6

Table 1: Rondo's box scores against Houston

There are a lot of numbers here, so I'll highlight Rondo's best games and most memorable moments from the series. This is possible due to the NBA having clips for each field goal attempt, assist, turnover, etc. available on their box score pages, and I have to give a huge thanks to the [Smart Highlights](#) YouTube channel. They compiled full games worth of clips (not just highlights!) of Rondo's performances into a single video, making research a thousand times easier. I watched their videos for every playoff game that Rondo played in the 2020 Playoffs.

Rondo - WCSF Game 2: He's back

After an uneven Game 1, Rondo asserted himself in Game 2. Plus-minus isn't a perfect stat, but he was a staggering +28 in an eight-point win. His return gave the Lakers exactly what they needed: Bothering Westbrook, playing passing lanes, finding open shooters, making Markieff Morris look like Dirk, and carving the Rockets up in transition. Every time Rondo checked into the game, he gave the Lakers a huge lift. The Rockets left him open a lot; he missed nearly all of his threes, but he made a couple of pull-up midrange shots in the fourth quarter, including a dagger with a minute left.

Rondo - WCSF Game 3: If You Thought Game 2 was Good

In Games 1-2, Rondo shot 7-18 and 3-10 from three. He was not shy about keeping the Rockets honest, but a 47.2 *eFG%* is not an efficient mark. Rondo has managed to be a very valuable player without a reliable jumpshot, but he needed to make his threes to be effective. He shot 3-5 in Game 3.

The strong shooting and playmaking left the Rockets scrambling, as he was able to beat Harden and Westbrook off the dribble! He saved his best for last: he had 12 points and 5 assists in the fourth quarter alone. The Lakers' first NINETEEN points in the quarter were all thanks to Rondo:

Assist, Assist, Made 3, Made 3, Layup, Assisted 3, Assist, Layup

He was magnificent and played a huge role in the Lakers taking a 2-1 lead.

Rondo - WCSF Game 4

Rondo posted a near triple-double and his third straight game with ten points and eight assists. The Rockets made a run late in the fourth quarter after being down by 23 midway through; that was a huge reason for Rondo's negative plus-minus.

This was the third game in a row where Rondo gave the Lakers huge minutes off the bench. He was able to provide the Lakers with another supercomputer on floor so LeBron could get his rest. Him and Alex Caruso were X-factors off the bench in Game 4.

Not much was needed from Rondo in Game 5; the Lakers were dominant from wire to wire. His only bucket came in the fourth quarter to put the Lakers up by 30. The Rockets were done. Up next were the Denver Nuggets fresh off their second consecutive 3-1 comeback.

Rondo - WCF Game 1: The Rondo Show

Those stats don't jump off the page, but he played an exceptionally entertaining 7-point, 9-assist game. Him and Anthony Davis were torturing the Nuggets with their alley-oop connection and Rondo hit a beautiful floater from behind the backboard. The Lakers finally won a Game 1 in the playoffs after falling behind 0-1 in the first two rounds.

Gm	Score	MIN	FG	3PT	FT	REB (OFF)	AST	TOV	STL	PTS	+/-
G1	126-114	22	3-7	1-1	0-0	1 (0)	9	0	2	7	+13
G2	105-103	21	1-3	1-2	0-0	4 (1)	9	5	1	3	+6
G3	106-114	30	4-10	0-3	1-3	2 (0)	8	4	3	9	-13
G4	114-108	22	4-6	1-1	2-4	5 (2)	7	1	0	11	-9
G5	117-107	13	3-5	2-4	0-0	3 (0)	4	1	0	8	-4

Table 2: Rondo's box scores against Denver

Rondo - WCF Game 2: Two Seconds

Rondo gave a sloppy performance in Game 2. His five turnovers tied a season-high. The Lakers took an early lead, but the Nuggets came roaring back in the third quarter, where Rondo conceded three giveaways. He threw several risky passes throughout the game that led to the five turnovers.

Despite those turnovers, Rondo still had eight assists going into the last possession of the game. Rondo was actually seated on the bench. The Lakers were down by one with twenty seconds left. Caruso missed a good look and Danny Green's second shot attempt was blocked out of bounds by Jamal Murray. [Two seconds left.](#)

Both teams were allowed to make substitutions. Mason Plumlee checked in for Nikola Jokić and Rondo checked in for Caruso. Rondo was the inbound man and delivered a sweet bounce pass to an in-rhythm AD for the game-winning three and assist number nine.

Rondo - WCF Game 3: The Rondo Show Almost Goes On

Denver blitzed LA and accumulated a huge lead early in the game. The Lakers were down 91-71 with 1:30 left in the third quarter. Rondo ignited a Lakers comeback rally to begin the fourth quarter. In about eight minutes of game time, the Lakers went on a 27-10 run to cut the deficit to three with 5:26 left in the game. Rondo was marvelous:

4 pts (2-3 FG, 0-1 3P, 0-1 FT), 3 ast, 1 tov, 3 stl during the run

All three of his steals came in a two-minute span; he was everywhere. The rally ultimately fell short, but Rondo again provided a spark.

Rondo - WCF Game 4: One big quarter

Rondo's Game 4 stats don't jump off the page, but he made some very crucial plays in back half of the fourth quarter to help the Lakers take a commanding 3-1 lead.

- Smart pass to Kentavious Caldwell-Pope after slowing down a fast break for a huge three (5:17, 103-96)
- Confident pull up midrange jumper (2:49, 107-102)
- Grabbed a game-sealing offensive rebound¹ for the Lakers (0:33, 111-106)

Just like in the semi-finals, Rondo didn't do much in Game 5. He played a playoff-low thirteen minutes and once again fed AD repeatedly. He, along with the rest of us, watched as LeBron had a dominant 38/16/10 triple double and drilled dagger after dagger in the fourth quarter. The Lakers won their third straight series in five games and earned a trip to the NBA Finals against a battle-tested Miami Heat team.

Benchmark

Before moving on to the Finals, I need to point out that Rajon Rondo shot 13-29 from three in the semis and conference finals. That's 44.8%.

Time	3PA/g	3P%	<i>eFG%</i>	<i>TS%</i>
2006-19 Playoffs	1.2	28.9%	45.6%	48.5%
2019-20 Regular Season	2.6	32.8%	48.0%	49.4%
2020 WCSF and WCF	2.9	44.8%	59.0%	59.2%

Table 3: Rondo's three-point shooting improvement

I mentioned earlier that Rondo would need to be able to contribute with his scoring to be truly effective, and he absolutely did that.

¹Remember, this is before the NBA instituted the offensive rebound 14-second reset rule, so Rondo grabbing that rebound gave the Lakers a full 24 second shot clock.

This was a recent improvement in Rondo's game. In the 2017-18 postseason with the New Orleans Pelicans, Rondo shot well from beyond the arc (8-19 in nine games)². He shot 30% or better from three only once in his first eight seasons. From 2014-20, Rondo shot better than 30% in every season, including above 35% three times, and he attempted 100 threes in five of those seasons (Figure 1).

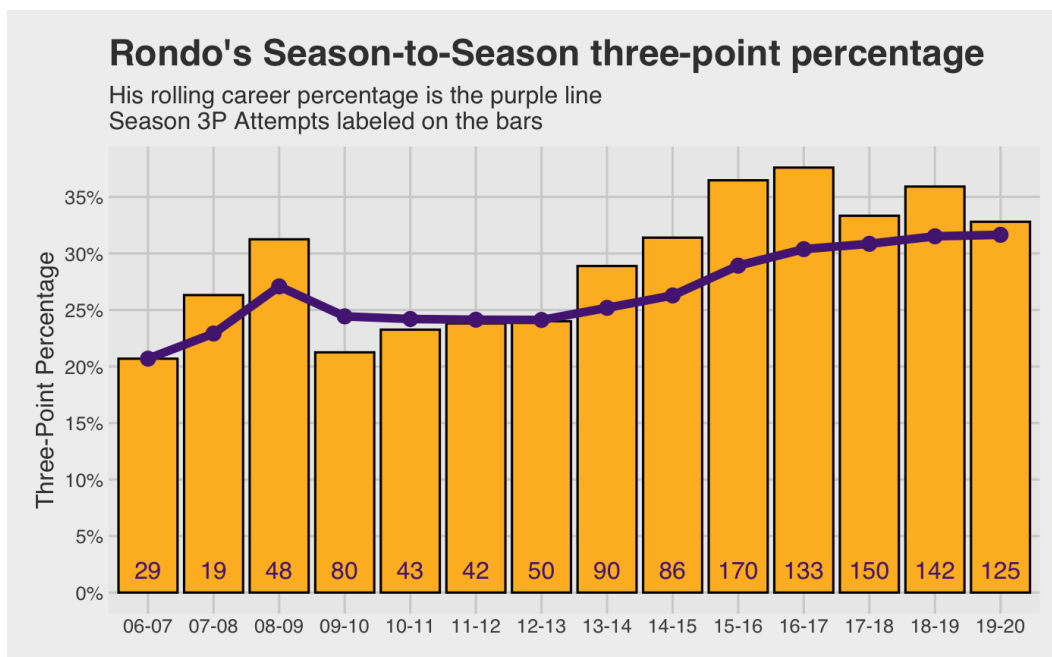


Figure 1: Rondo's career three-point shooting improvement

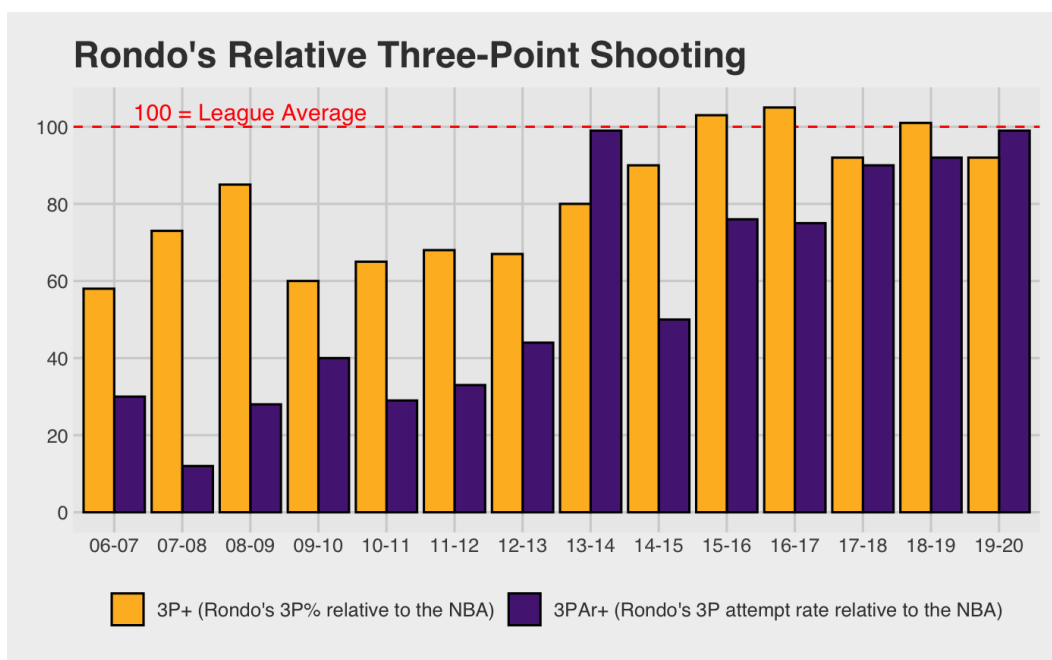


Figure 2: Rondo's relative three-point shooting

Figure 2 reinforces that Rondo became a stronger and more willing three-point

²Playoff Rondo is real, man

shooter. Three of his last five seasons were above average in terms of $3P\%$, and his volume is still below average, but compared to where he was in the previous decade, it's a huge jump.

Gm	Score	MIN	FG	3PT	FT	REB (OFF)	AST	TOV	STL	PTS	+/-
G1	116-98	25	2-7	1-5	2-2	3 (1)	4	1	0	7	+11
G2	124-114	26	5-9	3-4	3-4	4 (0)	10	1	0	16	+7
G3	104-115	28	2-8	0-3	0-0	8 (2)	5	2	2	4	+6
G4	102-96	28	1-7	0-2	0-0	7 (2)	5	1	1	2	+8
G5	108-111	18	1-7	0-3	2-2	5 (1)	5	1	2	4	-13
G6	106-93	30	8-11	3-4	0-0	4 (0)	4	4	1	19	+5

Table 4: Rondo's box scores against Miami

Rondo - Finals Game 2: Lethal

Game 1 was a modest performance from Rondo. He didn't shoot well, but he was part of a Lakers' 21-5 run in the first quarter. After a rough shooting night in Game 1, Rondo went 3-for-4 from beyond the arc in Game 2 and posted a double-double³. The Heat got huge production off of the bench; Kelly Olynyk and Kendrick Nunn combined for 37 points, so the Lakers needed a spark of their own coming off the bench.

As was the case throughout the postseason, Rondo continued his torrid three-point shooting from the left wing (Figure 3 from Positive Residual).

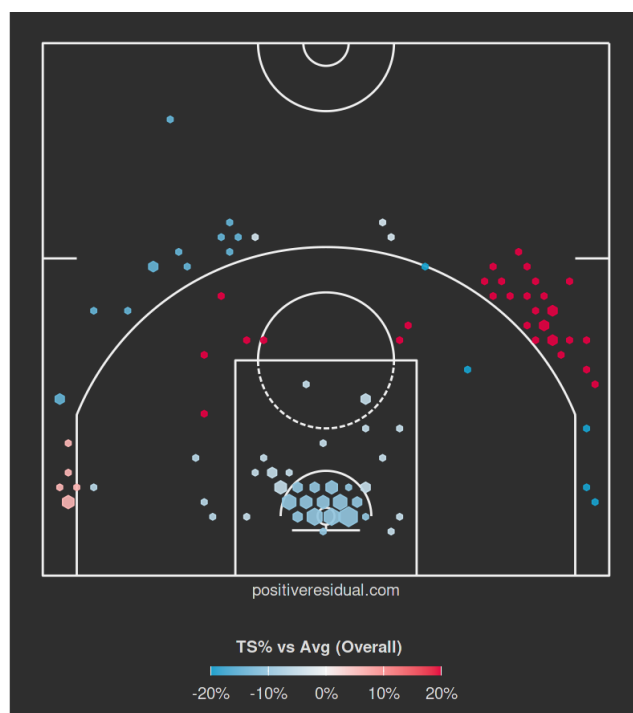


Figure 3: Rondo's relative shot chart from the 2020 postseason

That left wing was Rondo's most frequent jump-shooting spot, and it was his strongest area from beyond the arc. That elbow jumper was also clicking. He was not shooting

³Were his last two assists padded? Sure, but it's all good.

well from those areas by his standards; he was objectively shooting extremely proficiently from the left wing and both elbows.

This shot chart highlights a weakness that partially caused Rondo's poor shooting nights: His poor finishing at the rim. Rondo shot 48.6% on shots around the rim (0-3 feet), while the league average was 67.2%. Rondo was shooting very well from three, but his free throw percentage was around his usual range. Even if Rondo drew fouls on drives to the rim, it still wasn't very fruitful.

Game 3 was one to forget for the Lakers' starters. LeBron and AD combined for thirteen turnovers, KCP and Danny Green shot a combined 1-11, and both AD and KCP were -26. Jimmy Butler had a huge 40/13/11 triple-double to keep Miami alive in the series. The Lakers bench showed up; Morris and Kyle Kuzma both scored 19, and these two, along with Rondo and Caruso, had a positive plus-minus.

Rondo - Finals Game 4: On The Surface

Game 4 looks very ugly, but Rondo had a few high-impact moments throughout the game. Rondo played horribly in the first quarter, but played much better in the second quarter. He had three assists, a big offensive rebound, and a steal. The Heat were trying to pull away, but Rondo's timely plays kept the game close; he was a team-high +8. His only bucket came in a huge situation; he made a layup to put the Lakers up by six with less than a 1:30 to go.

Game 5 was ugly with no room for a positive spin. Rondo was a -13 in a three-point loss, he played a Finals-low eighteen minutes, and he didn't play much in the fourth quarter.

Rondo - Finals Game 6: Responding

Rajon Rondo was magnificent in the Lakers' title-clinching game. He was the second-leading scorer-tied with Anthony Davis! His first half was brilliant: 13 points (6-6 FG, 1-1 3P), 4 rebounds, 2 assists (1 turnover), +23 +/- . He even beat Jimmy Butler off the dribble twice!

The Lakers entered halftime leading by a staggering 28 points, and they were leading by as many as 34 points in the third quarter. The Heat made a fake comeback late in the game, but the game was over. For the second time, Rajon Rondo was an NBA champion and played a huge role in securing that ring.

Redemption

Dwight Howard was following a similar career path entering the 2019-20 season. The 34-year-old signed a one-year deal with Los Angeles as a depth piece after DeMarcus Cousins's torn ACL [7]. The Lakers would be Dwight's fifth team in five seasons; the last four teams were in a rush to let Dwight go. He gained a negative reputation since his first stint with the Lakers; despite having a 32/30 game in the 2017-18 season with Charlotte, there was no strong market for his services.

Signing with the Lakers was a clear indicator that Howard was willing to sacrifice to play for a contender. He was 34 years old, played only nine games in 2018-19, and joined a depth chart with Anthony Davis and two-time champion JaVale McGee.

Entering 2019-20, Howard had played 1044 games in his career and started all but one of them. The 2020 season was quite a shock for him:

69 games (2 starts), 18.9 min, 7.5 pts (72.9 *FG%*), 7.3 reb, 1.1 blk
 Career-lows in starts, minutes, points, and rebounds

Looking at Dwight’s advanced stats (*REB%*, *BLK%*), he still performed very well and near his previous standards; it was just in less minutes. His field goal percentage was a career high by a wide margin (previous high was 63.3%).

Howard - Staying Ready

Dwight Howard struggled to stay on the floor in the first two rounds of the 2020 playoffs. He committed five fouls in three of the five games against Portland. And Houston? The 2020 Rockets ran the ultimate small-ball lineup; their “center” was some combination of P.J. Tucker and Robert Covington. Both McGee and Howard were not good fits in this series.

The Western Conference Finals would once again require Dwight Howard’s services. The Denver Nuggets were led by their burgeoning star center Nikola Jokić. The Lakers would have to blow the dust off their center rotation after the series against the Rockets.

We must remember: Howard was 34 years old, but he was a former three-time Defensive Player of the Year. Prime Dwight was an absolute monster. He would have to tap into some of that previous excellence to help the Lakers get past the Nuggets.

Gm	Score	Start	MIN	FG	FT	REB (OFF)	STL	BLK	FLS	PTS	+/-
G1	126-114		16	4-5	5-8	3 (1)	2	2	4	13	+14
G2	105-103		13	1-1	1-1	2 (0)	1	0	5	3	+10
G3	106-114		14	2-3	0-1	1 (1)	1	1	4	4	-1
G4	114-108	*	23	5-6	2-3	11 (6)	1	0	2	12	+7
G5	117-107	*	35	3-4	3-6	9 (2)	0	2	5	9	+12

Table 5: Howard’s box scores against Denver

From a box score standpoint, this was Howard’s most impactful series. He posted a plus-minus of +10 or greater in three of the five games (Figure 4).

However, this series requires a deeper dive to do it justice. Much of the research credit has to go to [this video](#) from Next Level Hoops on YouTube. It is a compilation of Dwight Howard making Jokić’s life a living hell. The former DPOY briefly showed himself in the five game series.

Howard - WCF Game 1: Taking My Spot

Dwight Howard scored a series-high 13 points in Game 1. His work on the defensive end was far more notable. He only played 16 minutes and he forced two fouls on the Joker and got a steal as well. Saying he made Jokić’s life harder is not hyperbole; he did it all series (Table 6).

Howard checked in?	MIN	FG	FGA	REB	PF
Yes	87:35	15	25	13	12
No	79:32	26	52	23	11

Table 6: Jokić’s splits when Howard was checked in

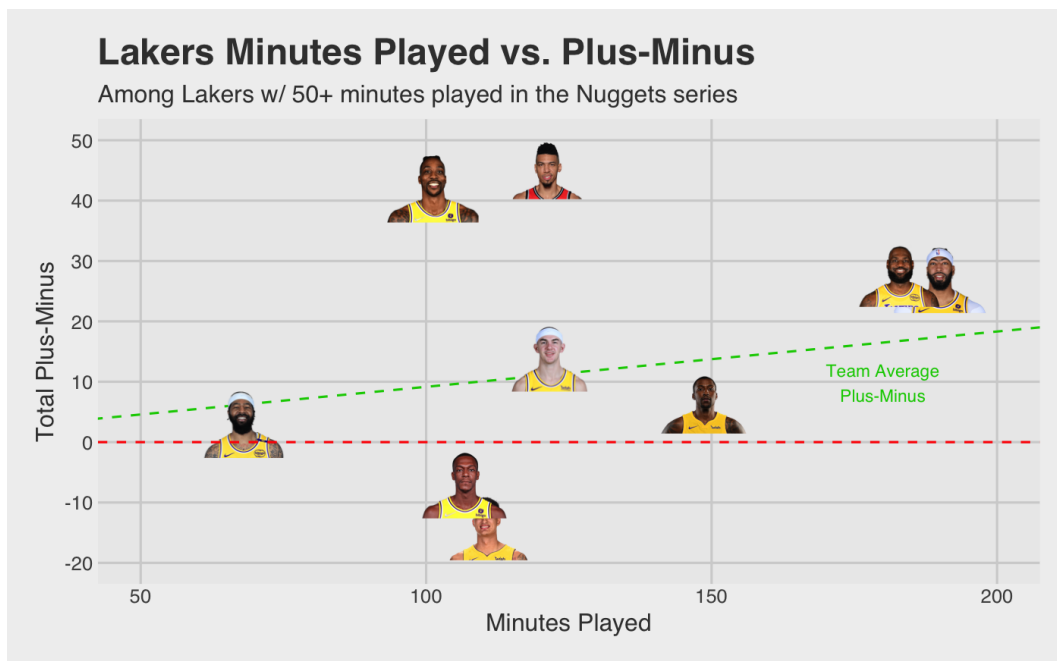


Figure 4: Dwight Howard’s huge impact in the conference finals

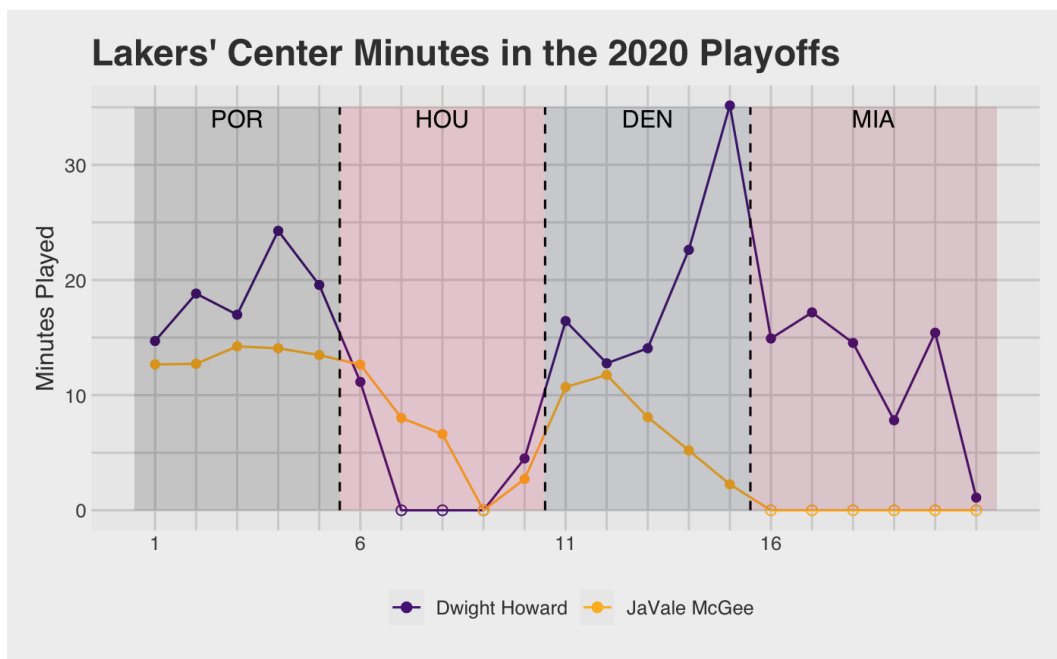


Figure 5: McGee lost his rotation spot during the Denver series

Did Howard “shut down” Nikola Jokić? No, and that was not the expectation⁴. As many analysts say, you can’t stop a great player, but you can make their lives harder. You can make things more difficult for them, and that’s what Dwight did. Jokić took far fewer shots, grabbed fewer rebounds, and was in foul trouble all series. The last point is due largely to the athletic Lakers front court featuring the three-headed monster of AD, McGee, and Howard. However, due to Howard’s strong play, something funny

⁴Anyone see Rudy Gobert in the 2026 Playoffs?? Maybe I’m wrong?

happened with the Lakers' rotation (Figure 5).

During Round One, the Lakers started McGee and played the two bigs roughly evenly. Howard was played off the court in the Rockets series, and then he became Coach Frank Vogel's main man in the Western Conference Finals. He became the starting center, and McGee had six straight DNP-CD's⁵ in the NBA Finals.

Howard - Slowing Down Greatness

The Lakers beat the Nuggets in five games. Nikola Jokić was neither inefficient nor bad, but he was not dominant. How could he have been? He wasn't able to play as many minutes.

Plain language: Nikola Jokić played less minutes on average in the WCF.

$$H_o: MP_{R1 \text{ and semis}} = MP_{WCF}$$

$$H_1: MP_{R1 \text{ and semis}} > MP_{WCF}$$

Plain language: Nikola Jokić committed more fouls on average in the WCF.

$$H_o: PF_{R1 \text{ and semis}} = PF_{WCF}$$

$$H_1: PF_{R1 \text{ and semis}} < PF_{WCF}$$

	Averages		<i>p</i> -value	
Stat	Before WCF	During WCF	Mann-Whitney	Brunner-Munzel
Minutes	37.7	33.4	0.0320	0.0125
Fouls	3.21	4.60	0.0076	0.0005

Table 7: Statistical test results for Jokić's minutes and fouls in the WCF.

Jokić wasn't able to play as much in the conference finals. He committed more than one additional foul per game despite playing fewer minutes. One could argue that this was due to a combination of factors separate from Howard: Anthony Davis being at the height of his powers or the Lakers having an incredible defense. However, I argue that Howard's defense was the primary reason. First, the video I linked shows how hard Howard made Jokić work on play after play. Second, we saw in Figure 5 that McGee played single-digit minutes from Games 3-5. Howard played 101 total minutes in the series and the two centers spent 87:35 on the court together (Table 6), which means that 87% of his minutes were alongside Jokić. Coach Vogel specifically deployed him to deal with the Serbian superstar. Third, look at the disparity in Jokić's points and rebounds when Howard was on the floor. Those differences are significant.

Jokić attempted fewer shots on average while Howard was on the floor.

$$H_o: FGA_{w \text{ D12}} = FGA_{w/o \text{ D12}}$$

$$H_1: FGA_{w \text{ D12}} < FGA_{w/o \text{ D12}}$$

Brunner-Munzel *p*-value: 0.0079

Jokić grabbed fewer rebounds on average while Howard was on the floor.

$$H_o: REB_{w \text{ D12}} = REB_{w/o \text{ D12}}$$

$$H_1: REB_{w \text{ D12}} < REB_{w/o \text{ D12}}$$

⁵Did Not Play - Coach's Decision

Note: The field goal attempts and rebounds are minute-adjusted.

Okay, so the difference in rebounds is technically not statistically significant at a 95% threshold, but it is extremely close. I believe that my point still stands.

Unlikely is Right

Markieff Morris? Indeed. Another guy who bounced from team to team. The Lakers were Morris's fourth team in two years. He was bought out by the Detroit Pistons and the Lakers signed him in mid-February. He played a much smaller role; he averaged career lows in minutes and points, and he shot only 33.3% from three.

The 2020 playoffs were an entirely different story. Markieff Morris shot 42% from beyond the arc on 3.3 attempts per game. He was one of two Lakers who played real minutes that shot 40% or better from three. The other? Rajon Rondo, because of course.

The Rockets series was an odd challenge for the Lakers. Houston's roster construction was absurd and it required adjustment on the part of the Lakers, especially after a Game 1 loss. Morris was called to action, and he responded.

Player	MIN	PTS	$eFG\%$	3PA	$3PAr$	$3P\%$	Gm w/ +/- ≥ 10
Markieff Morris	20.5	8.6	67.2%	18	.562	50.0%	4
LeBron James	35.6	25.8	56.7%	34	.378	29.4%	3
Danny Green	26.4	9.0	56.6%	26	.684	42.3%	2
Anthony Davis	37.3	25.4	61.2%	5	.062	40.0%	1
Rajon Rondo	26.6	10.6	61.0%	18	.439	44.4%	1
Kentavious Caldwell-Pope	28.2	7.2	56.2%	19	.594	42.1%	1
Alex Caruso	24.0	8.4	58.6%	17	.586	35.3%	0
Kyle Kuzma	24.5	11.2	62.2%	14	.341	35.7%	0

Table 8: Lakers' shooting stats in the Rockets series (min. 10 min/g)

The Lakers had to play drastic small-ball to match the Rockets. Morris started Games 4 and 5, and he gave the Lakers a huge spark from beyond the arc all series long. He scored sixteen points in both Game 2 and Game 5, and he had a double-digit positive plus-minus in Games 2-5. Again, plus-minus isn't a perfect stat, but to rack up such a high mark in relatively fewer minutes is not to be overlooked.

Morris was Coach Vogel's counter against the Rockets' odd lineup, and he delivered. He scored nine points a game, made half of his three-point attempts, and had the highest plus minus despite playing lighter minutes than the other rotational Lakers. What a series for the mid-season acquisition.

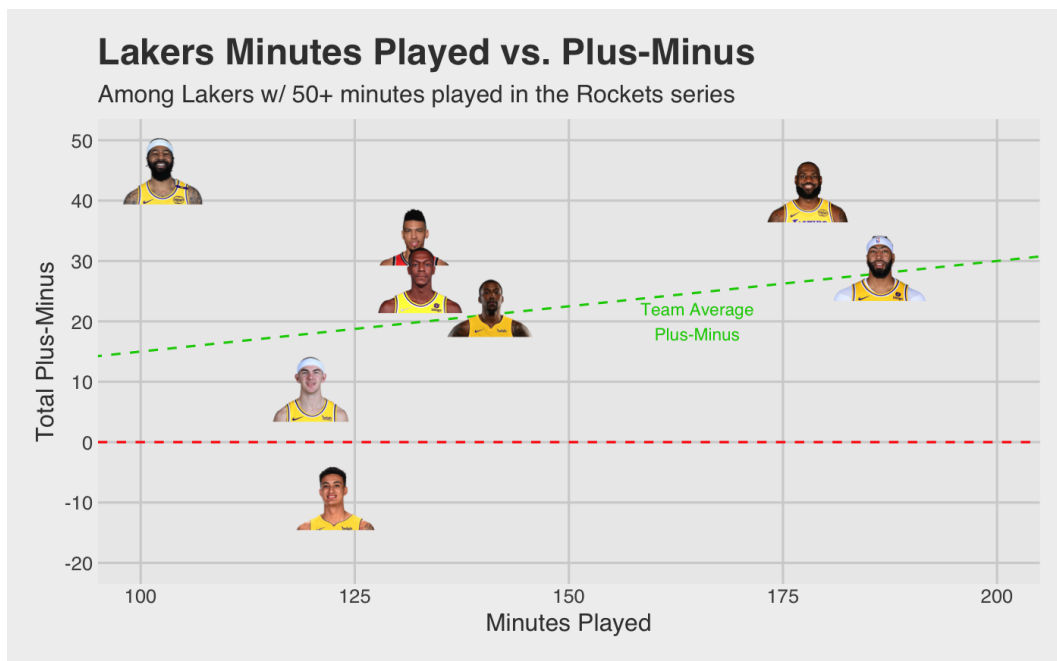


Figure 6: Markieff Morris’s huge impact in the semi-finals

Not Efficient, But Effective

Danny Green and Alex Caruso joined the Lakers under completely different circumstances. Green was on his third team in three seasons, but it wasn’t a negative thing; he was part of the Kawhi Leonard trade. He signed a two-year deal with the Lakers fresh off winning his second NBA championship with the Toronto Raptors the season before. Caruso, undrafted from Texas A&M, had played only 62 career games at the age of 25, but he had impressed the Lakers enough in 2018-19 (25 games, 9.2 pts, 48 3P%) to earn a guaranteed contract in 2019-20.

Green and Caruso shot a combined 31.8% from three in the Lakers’ 2020 playoff run. Danny Green was the subject of extreme scrutiny after missing a potential go-ahead three in Game 5 of the Finals. Alex Caruso became a meme on Inside The NBA, being called “Ernie’s son.” Despite all of that noise, these two were arguably the most important Lakers not named LeBron James or Anthony Davis in the 2020 playoffs.

Here’s a quick explanation of how to interpret the green line. The Lakers had a point differential of +144 in the 2020 playoffs. They played 21 games and didn’t play in overtime once, so they roughly had an average point differential of $\frac{144}{21 \times 48} = \frac{1}{7}$ points per minute. Being north of the green line means your minutes were above the team average in terms of point differential.

Danny Green and Caruso played around 500 minutes each and yet their plus-minus was above +100. Plus-minus is flawed, so here is databallr’s adjusted version of On-Off (Figure 8)

This is the crux of my argument. Dwight Howard was magnificent for the Conference Finals, but struggled to be effective in the other three series. Rajon Rondo had many huge games, but he had a few stinkers, and he struggled defensively at points throughout the playoffs. Markieff Morris gave reliable minutes, but his peak was certainly during the Rockets series. Alex Caruso and Danny Green were impactful every night.

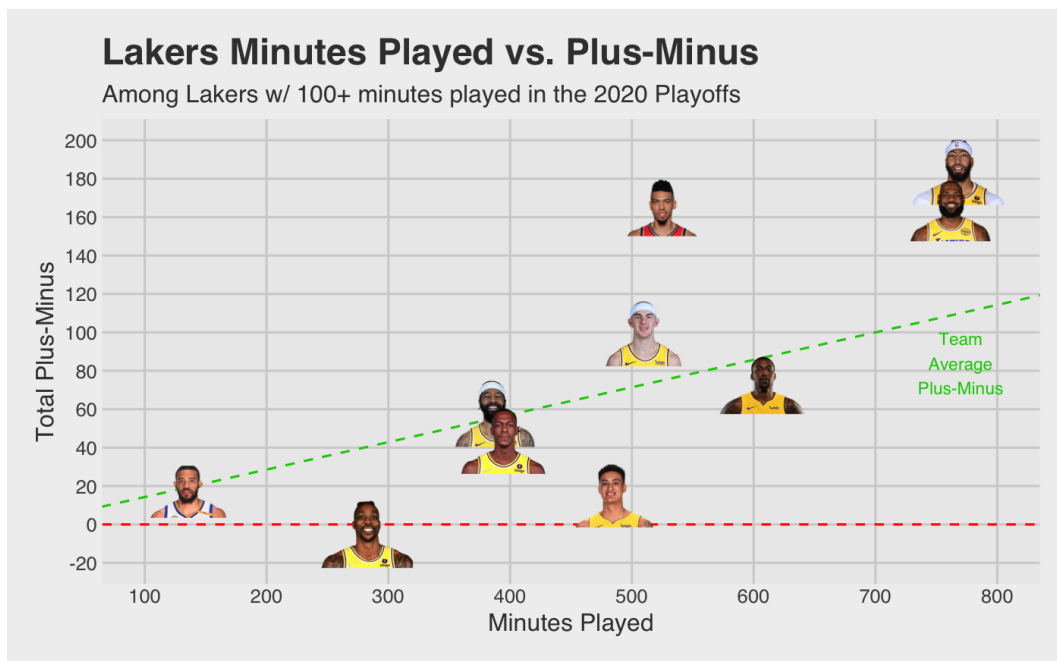


Figure 7: The Lakers' plus-minus in the 2020 playoffs

PLAYER	MIN min	NET	NET ON-OFF
Anthony Davis	687	+11.5	+1.5
LeBron James	664	+13.3	+9.3
Kentavious Caldwell-Pope	539	+8.5	-7.3
Danny Green	464	+15.8	+9.9
Alex Caruso	424	+12.8	+3.3
Kyle Kuzma	411	+6.7	-8.7
Markieff Morris	337	+13.2	+3.2
Rajon Rondo	332	+9.9	-2.1
Dwight Howard	242	+6.2	-7.0
JaVale McGee	116	+9.9	-1.4

Figure 8: The Lakers' On-Off with Low Leverage Minutes Removed

What made the 2020 Lakers a great team wasn't just their dynamic duo: It was their defensive identity. The Lakers ranked third in the NBA in defensive rating in

the regular season. They ranked sixth in the postseason, but they ranked first in net rating. Along with Anthony Davis, Caruso and Green were huge parts of that identity. That's how they were able to accumulate incredibly positive on-off numbers despite poor shooting and inconsistent offensive output.

Concluding Remarks

It wasn't known at the time, but the 2020 Lakers were the peak of the LeBron era in Los Angeles. Future seasons were doomed by injuries, poor roster construction, and emerging powerhouses in the West. The Lakers have not recreated that perfect combination they had in 2020. Along with great play, they also had supreme cohesion and chemistry. It was easily visible when you observed the bench reactions; they were playing for each other. We can't quantify vibes, but we can quantify the unique impact their role players had en route to the Lakers' 2020 championship run.

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- [11] Data visualizations were made using R’s ggplot2.
- [12] Data manipulation and aggregation was done using Python and R.